

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

former self—the firebrand leader he was known to be ever since entering the student politics at Patna University in the 1970s. But things seem to have worked out well for him after the transplant, followed by recuperation in Delhi.

In fact, Lalu did not take a break even for a week after his return to Patna on April 28. On May 3, he was seen personally serving fish and chicken curry to the RJD legislators during a get-together at his residence. That personal touch apart, Lalu told his MLAs to tour the state and back the year-old Mahagathbandhan (MGB), or Grand Alliance, government led by Bihar chief minister and Janata Dal (United)'s de facto supremo Nitish Kumar. Lalu himself has done just that, as was evident during two incidents in July alone. First, when an "ego battle" between the RJD's education minister Chandrashekhar and an IAS officer threatened to snowball into a major discord between the two alliance partners, Lalu backed Nitish's decision to continue with the officer who has been tasked with improving the quality of education in government schools. The RJD chief also silenced his old loyalist and legislative council member Sunil Singh, who had called JD(U) minister Ashok Choudhary "untrustworthy". In fact, in a closed-door meeting, Lalu is reported to have told his party MLAs not to sweat the "small things" and focus on the bigger electoral battle next year.

Though Lalu's public posturing has been belligerent and homespun, MGB insiders concede that he has had a calming effect on the alliance. Of the 160 MLAs who back the Nitish Kumar government, Lalu's RJD alone has 79, making it the single-largest party in the Bihar assembly. Yet, instead of flexing his political muscle as perhaps a 'lesser' politician may have done, the way Lalu has reined in his overenthusiastic partymen, telling them not to go overboard while asserting their loyalty towards Tejashwi, only goes to show how seasoned a politician-patriarch he is.

If last year, the RJD accepted Nitish's decision to make two of its ministers resign—sugarcane industry minister Kartik Singh in August 2022 followed by agriculture minister Sudhakar Singh in October—without any demur, it was largely because Lalu wants his party to let Nitish run the government unencumbered. Nitish is known to be a stickler for the rules, who does not like any kind of interference in his working, and Lalu is backing his old friend-turned-foe-turned-friend to the hilt. In fact, unlike during the earlier MGB government that was in power between November 2015 and July 2017, Lalu has not been making calls to bureaucrats as frequently as he used to.

RJD insiders who talked to INDIA TODAY on the condition of anonymity say even before his kidney transplant, Lalu was instrumental in the rapprochement between the two parties